

The story of Mahājanaka Mahājanaka Jātaka (539)

Vol. VI, 30–68

Discussion about the story

The condition of all beings, *saṃsāra*, is often described as an ocean in ancient Indian thought. The codifier of law, Manu, categorizes those that have undertaken a sea journey with those who should be excluded from rituals: purification would be required after any voyage.¹ Buddhism, however, travelled with mercantile interests that crossed oceans and so depended upon sea travel for its dissemination.² This story is most widely known through a maritime image, of the Bodhisatta being rescued by a goddess after swimming for seven days on his own after a shipwreck. It is one of the most frequently depicted scenes in the temple art of Sri Lanka and Thailand, both seafaring nations. Despite the story's link with renunciation, the scene in the ocean prompted ancient sources to associate it with the perfection of vigour or effort (*virīya*), a word cognate to the Latin word for 'man' (*vir*) and hence English words such as virility and virtuosity. The introduction to the Jātakas says, 'All the men died in the middle of the ocean, with no shore in sight; but there was nothing at variance in my mind (*cittassa aññathā*) and this is the perfection of effort.'³ Mahājanaka's valiant attempts to survive are treated in the tradition of the last ten Jātakas as representing this perfection too: in some depictions his effort looks as light as air, as if he is being lifted from the wreck by Mañimekhalā as he falls.⁴

The story's exploration of the nature of appropriate effort, 'with nothing at variance', is communicated with considerable dramatic skill. Winternitz says of its 'overwhelming power' that it could only have been inspired 'by the deepest inner conviction and no less poetical talent'.⁵ Split into two distinct sections, the tale nonetheless represents a unified sequence from the heroic quest of a prince to regain his throne, to the king's subsequent efforts to adopt the renunciate life. In the first part, the Bodhisatta shows a combination of courage and inventiveness characteristic of a folk hero. The taunting of the brahmin boys about his birth when living in exile and the interchange with his mother in which he resists her advice not to go to sea show his strength before the ordeal of his survival for seven days after the shipwreck. This, however, along with his display of shrewd common sense to avoid death, is the real test of the Bodhisatta's mettle. After his long swim of seven days which culminates in his eloquent debate with the goddess, Mañimekhalā, he is tested by situations where the correct placing of effort lies in acquiescence, not action. He lets the goddess carry him to safety, the magical carriage that chooses a king goes straight to him while he sleeps and the kingship is offered to him rather than being claimed. When the two protagonists come together, tests of wit and skill are needed. In this, many features are recognizable from the ordeals and romantic courtships of folk traditions around the world, particularly where a throne is concerned.⁶ Sivalī seems to represent the glories of the city of Mithilā. She herself has imposed a quick and gruelling test on the earlier candidates for her hand—a ruthless piece of character assessment whose shaming echoes the routing of Penelope's suitors and the abasement of the sailors by Circe in the Odyssey. This is the first time that she herself has been tested. The prince parries her demands, by paying attention to the palace rather than her, and changes the rules of engagement. Unlike the other humiliated suitors, he proceeds at his own pace, does

not search her out, but waits for her to choose him, which she does, by accepting him with her hand. Throughout this part of the story we see the need for different kinds of effort, not all requiring obvious strain or 'brawn'. Mahājanaka's silent recognition of his subjects while lying on the stone, his regal response to the tests of the princess, and his careful measuring of what is necessary as, for instance, in the stringing of the bow, a task that he performs with an ease compared to women carding cotton, are all achievements that contribute to his suitability to be king.

With the solving of the riddles another key influence in the tale is introduced. Riddle-solving forms a central part of the accumulation of wisdom in Jātakas (as in Jātaka 402). In Sri Lanka, they are still, to this day, a popular means of encoding medical, psychological and esoteric knowledge.⁷ The riddles here have a particular significance: the earlier king had oriented his life by waiting upon the *paccekabuddhas*, ascetics who lived on his generosity in alms, every day at dawn and sunset. By recognizing the honour they were paid by the last king, and hence the true spiritual alignment of Mithilā, the new king discovers the secrets encrypted in the old king's riddles. In the time when there is no Buddhist path, there is no means for obtaining arahatship, which requires the teaching of a fully awakened Buddha. This curious shadow or absence hangs like a backdrop over all the Jātakas, but *paccekabuddhas*, barely mentioned in other *nikāyas*, are a reminder that it is a temporary one, and that spirituality can never be lost completely.⁸ Many stories describe them and their path to enlightenment.⁹ It is the yearning for their reassuring presence after they leave that leads the Bodhisatta to renunciation: the three simple and lyrical verses (vv. 22–4) in which he expresses his sense of loss at their departure—unexplained in the narrative—are a testament to the values they represent. In the last part of the story, striking images associated with *paccekabuddhas* in other

Jātakas govern the Bodhisatta's effort as he tries to take up the holy life. The tree that is beautiful but which bears no fruit, an analogy for the life of the recluse, and the girl with a solitary bangle are both images famously described elsewhere as instigating the enlightenment of those who become *paccekabuddhas*.¹⁰ *Paccekas*, in the absence of a teacher, were thought to find freedom through the teaching of a meaningful event. The Bodhisatta can never become a *paccekabuddha*: his ultimate aim is to become, in his last lifetime, a fully awakened Buddha, who can teach a complete way to others. Even up to his final departure, however, with the obliteration of footprints that might find him, his efforts to take up the holy life are punctuated by a series of memorable events and encounters that align him with these often silent and mysterious figures, the *paccekas*; like them he finds his path on his own, but others cannot follow him.

Key events in the story are resolved in an almost palpable silence. While there is great poetry, skilled debate between protagonists and an extensive eulogy to the city of Mithilā (vv. 25–115), major agreements are unspoken. Mahājanaka's assessment of the crowd as his subjects while lying on the stone, Sivali's acceptance of him as her husband and her placing of the golden pin to help him answer the riddle about the head of the bed, all take place without discussion. The populace complain of the king's silence when he has assumed the attitude of a *paccekabuddha* (v. 21). The king copies their walk and behaviour, not their speech, to prepare himself for his departure. When he passes down from the palace Sivali silently and symbolically frees him to renounce his kingship by paying respects to the man she thinks is a *paccekabuddha*: though the fact that she thinks it is such a figure who has been teaching shows that these enlightened beings do teach sometimes. The little girl's bangle is a silent teacher (vv. 157–9). The fletcher is silent when he has given his advice (vv. 165–7). Unlike the Vessantara Jātaka (547), where the

You may skim through the story but read the section marked as Mahajanaka's sea journey and rescue

Bodhisatta revives his swooning wife, Mahājanaka disappears without a word into the forest when she is unconscious: his strenuous attempts to dismiss her, and hence the crowds that follow her, have been to no avail.¹¹ Although the king's rejection of Sivali in this story seems cruel, those who heard the story would have seen it as part of the Bodhisatta's larger search, which culminates in Buddhahood, at a time when he can teach Sivali to find enlightenment for herself. In this story she seems to represent the lay life and her people; his is a particularly lone way.

As if to highlight the power of silence, a special place is also accorded to the role of noise and music in this Jātaka. Musical instruments accompany the wonderful carriage and roar like the sea to greet the Bodhisatta. Songs and music at his first festival are like the roar of the Yugandhara ocean. The first thing people notice about him when he becomes a recluse is that he does not listen to songs or music (v. 20). The renunciate king remembers the music before the visual beauty that had accompanied his entrance to the garden where he saw the two trees (vv. 144–9). The twofold structure of the story seems to create a parallel between Mahājanaka's lone escape from the waters and his attempts to become an ascetic. A noise, compared to village games, is produced by the streaming crowds that surround him as he leaves Mithilā (v. 129). In the vow that opens this book the Bodhisatta describes himself as one who will take others across the sea of existence.¹² Perhaps because it is a tale about the development of heroic effort, however, the most famous scene in this story is the rescue by the goddess of a man on his own. It is a curious and even contradictory image for this perfection—and apt in a story so influenced by the *paccekabuddhas*, who find enlightenment for themselves (*sāmaṇi*). The hero, as Bodhisatta, cannot find complete release in this lifetime and so does not become one of their number, but this Jātaka bears the stamp of their solitary path.¹³

Story from the present

'Who is this in the middle of the ocean?'

While staying at the Jetavana Grove the Teacher told this story about renunciation. One day the monks sat down in the *dharmā* hall and were praising the great renunciation of the Thus-gone. The Teacher came in and said, 'So what then, bhikkhus, have you been discussing while you have been meeting together?' They told him the subject. 'This, bhikkhus, is not the first occasion that I have made a great renunciation.' And he narrated this story about times long past.

Story from the past

Once upon a time at Mithilā, in the kingdom of Videha, a king ruled called Mahājanaka.¹⁴ He had two sons, Ariṭṭhajanaka and Polajanaka. The king handed over the viceroyship to the elder of these and the position of leader of the army to the younger. In course of time Mahājanaka died and Ariṭṭhajanaka became the king and gave the viceroyship to the other. A certain foot servant of his went into the presence of the king and said, 'Sire, the viceroy wishes to kill you.' When he heard this story from him again and again the king became divided from Polajanaka and had him placed in chains and put in a house near the royal palace. He ordered him to be put under guard. The prince made a declaration of truth:¹⁵ 'If I have been an enemy to my brother, may my chains not become loosened and may the door not open; if I have not, may my chains loosen and may the door open.' Sure enough the bonds [31] broke, chain by chain, and the door opened. So he left and went to a border town and set up house; the inhabitants of the border town recognized him and waited upon him. The king could not manage to get him captured. Polajanaka eventually went to the borderland that had come into his

possession, with a large retinue, saying, 'I was not my brother's enemy before, but I certainly am now.' So he went to Mithilā with a large following of people and settled his army outside the city. The city dwellers heard, 'Polajanaka has come,' and almost all went, with elephants and other vehicles, to join him; and other cities also came. He sent a message to his brother: 'I was not your enemy before, but now I am. Give me the royal parasol—or battle.' The king went to give him battle and warned his chief queen: 'Dear lady, it is impossible to know in war whether there will be victory or defeat, or if I should meet with a fatal injury. Please guard our unborn child.' Saying this, he left. Then, in battle Polajanaka's warriors killed him.

When it was reported that the king was dead there was confusion in the entire city. The queen heard of his death and as quickly as possible she laid gold and other treasures into a basket, spread a small cloth over it and sprinkled husked rice over that. She then dressed herself in a stained garment and, making her body look unattractive, put the basket on her head and left early in the day, so that no one would recognize her. She left by the northern gate. As she had not been anywhere before she did not know the road and could not work out the directions, but she had heard that there was a city called Campā. So she sat down and asked if there were people going to Campā.

Now, the child in her womb was not just anyone, but the Great Being, who had taken rebirth and was filled with the perfections; the world of Sakka shook with his glory. And Sakka, wondering, realized the cause of this: 'In this lady's womb a being of great merit has taken rebirth; I must go.' When he had decided this he conjured up a covered chariot and prepared a couch in it and, as if he were an old man driving the carriage, stood at the door of the house where she was sitting and asked if there was anyone wanting to go to Campā. 'I would like to, sir.' [32] 'Then, good lady, get up into my carriage.' 'But sir, I am very far gone

in my pregnancy and it is not possible for me to get into the carriage. I'll go behind, just give me space for this basket.' 'What are you saying, dear lady? For sure, there is no one as strong in the skill of driving a carriage as me. Don't worry, just get up into the carriage and sit down.' Through his powers he caused the earth to rise just at the moment when she was getting into the carriage so that it joined the back of it. Realizing that this was a god she got on the couch and lay down. And the moment that she lay down on the divine bed, she fell fast asleep. When Sakka had gone a distance of thirty yojanas and come to a river, he woke her up. 'Madam, get down and bathe in the river. At the head of the bed there is a cloak. Put it on. There is a pan-cooked cake at the front of the carriage; eat that,' he said. As soon as she had done so she fell fast asleep again. When it was evening they reached Campā and she saw the gate, the watchtower and the walls. 'What is this city?' she asked. He replied that it was the city of Campā. 'How do you explain this, sir? Surely the distance from our city to Campā is a good seven yojanas?' 'Certainly lady, but I know a direct route.' He then got her to get down by the southern gate. 'Lady, my village is further on—you enter the city here.' When he had said this Sakka went on ahead and then vanished and went back to his own realm.

The queen sat down in a certain hall. At that moment a certain citizen of Campā, a brahmin reciter of verses with a retinue of five hundred young attendants, was on his way to bathe and saw her sitting there, lovely and restored to beauty. The moment he saw her, by the power of the being in her womb, he conceived the great affection that one feels for a younger sister. Seeing that the youths remained standing there he entered the hall alone, addressed her as sister and asked her in which city she lived. She replied that she was the principal queen of King Aritthajanaka of Mithilā. 'Why have you come here?' he asked. 'The king has been killed by Polajanaka, and I was frightened, thinking that I

must escape to protect my baby.' 'Have you any relative in this city?' he asked. 'None, sir,' she said. 'Then do not worry, I am a brahmin of the north, a teacher from a great house whose fame is widespread. I will install you as my sister and look after you. Call me brother and clasp my feet in grief.' She fell at his feet and made a great lament, and they each grieved over the other. [33] His attendants ran up and asked, 'What is going on, teacher?' 'This is my younger sister; she was born at a certain time when I was not there,' he said. They replied, 'Do not be troubled as from now on you will be able to see her.'

So he brought a large covered carriage and sat her in it. Saying to the driver, 'Good man, tell my wife that this is my sister and tell her to take care of everything,' he sent her home. His wife saw that she bathed in hot water, had a bed prepared for her and got her to rest. When the brahmin had bathed and come home at the time of the meal he said, 'Sister, please dine with me.' And he ate together with her and continued to watch over her within his house. Not long afterwards she gave birth to a son, and he was called Prince Mahājanaka, after his grandfather. And as he grew up he played with other boys, and when they teased him with their own pure and high-caste birth he would hit them hard on account of his great strength and stout heart. They used to wail with a loud noise and when asked who had beaten them used to say that it was 'the widow's son'. The prince wondered why they kept on calling him 'the widow's son' and decided to consult his mother. One day he asked her: 'Mother, who was my father?' She deceived him and said, 'My child, the brahmin is your father.' When they hit him on another day and called him 'the widow's son' he replied, 'Actually, I am the brahmin's son'. They said, 'What has the brahmin to do with you?' So he thought about this. 'They ask me what the brahmin has to do with me, and my mother does not explain the reason

and will not do so out of pride in herself. I'll make sure she does explain it to me.' While drinking at her breast he bit her there and said, 'Tell me about my father, or I will cut your breast off.'¹⁶ This time she was unable to deceive him and explained, 'You are the son of king Ariṭṭhajanaka of Mithilā. Your father was killed by Polajanaka. I came to this city so that I could protect you. The brahmin installed me as a younger sister and took care of me.' And from that time on he was no longer angry when he was called 'the widow's son'.

Before he was sixteen he had learnt the three Vedas and all kinds of skills [34] and by the time he was sixteen he had become surpassingly handsome. Then he thought, 'I will seize the kingdom that belonged to my father.' He asked his mother, 'Mother, have you got any wealth to hand? If you do not, I will make some money and then seize the kingdom that belonged to my father.' She said, 'I did not come here empty-handed. There is a quantity of pearls, jewels and diamonds of great value for taking the kingdom.'¹⁷ Take it and claim the kingdom: do not ply any trade.' He replied, 'Mother, give me the wealth here, but I will take only half now. I will go to the Beautiful Land and bring back a large fortune and then seize the kingdom.' He got her to bring him half, collected his merchandise and put it on board a ship with some merchants setting out for the Beautiful Land. Then he said goodbye to his mother. When he told her where he was going she said, 'My son, there is not much success to be found at sea but there is a great deal of danger. Do not go, there is plenty of wealth for you to claim the kingdom.' He said, 'I must go, mother.' And so, bidding her farewell, he went on board the boat. On that day an illness struck Polajanaka's body and he could not get up from his bed.

On board there were seven hundred legs¹⁸ and in seven days the boat went seven hundred yojanas, but it sailed so fiercely that

it could not hold out and its boards split. The water rose higher and higher and the boat plunged into the midst of the ocean, while all the passengers and crew moaned and cried and invoked various gods. The Great Being, however, did not moan or cry or pray to deities but, seeing that the boat was about to sink, he beat together some ghee with sugar, ate a bellyful and then smeared two outer garments with sesame oil, tied them on tightly and stood leaning against the mast. When the boat did sink the mast stayed upright. The people on board became food for the fishes and tortoises while the water all around became red with blood. The Great Being, standing at the mast, determined the direction in which Mithilā lay and leapt from the mast, passing beyond the fishes and tortoises so that he fell one hundred and forty cubits from the boat. On that very day Polajanaka died. From then the Great Being went through the crystal-coloured waves and crossed the ocean like a heap of gold, and he spent seven days as if they were one. [35] Then he saw the shore, and washed his mouth out with salt water¹⁹ as it was an *uposatha* day. Now, a daughter of the gods called Maṇimekhalā, or Jewelled-girdle, had been appointed by the Four Guardian Kings as the protector of the oceans and told, 'It is not right for those who have reverence towards the mother and other such qualities to fall into the sea: look out for them.'²⁰ She did not watch the ocean for seven days, for it is said that her mindfulness had been forgotten while she enjoyed the results of bliss; though some say that she had met up with some shining gods. At any rate she said to herself, 'It has been seven days since I have kept watch on the sea. I wonder who has come by?' When she looked she saw the Great Being. She thought, 'If Prince Mahājanaka should perish in the ocean I would not keep my admission into the assembly of shining gods'. She assumed a well-adorned appearance and stood in the air not far from the Bodhisatta. As a test of his mettle she uttered the first verse:

1. 'Who are you, struggling, out of sight of the shore, in the middle of the ocean?
What aim do you pursue, and, knowing this, are making an effort so manfully?'

Then the Great Being said, 'Today is the seventh day that I have been crossing the ocean. I have seen no other being before. Who is it who is speaking to me?' As he gazed into the air and saw her he uttered a second verse:

2. 'Careful of my vow to struggle in the world, O Goddess: because of this I struggle, out of sight of the shore, in the middle of the ocean.'

Wishing to hear a *dhamma* talk she spoke a third verse:

3. 'In the deep and measureless [sea] where no shore can be seen your human struggle is useless, you will not reach the shore and you will die!'

Then the Great Being replied, 'What are you saying? If I die making all this effort I will be free from any blame.' And he uttered this verse:

4. [36] 'He that does things that should be done by humans is free from debt,
to relatives or to shining gods or to ancestors, and feels no regret afterwards.'

And then the goddess spoke this verse:

5. 'What is the point of effort if the deed cannot be achieved, is fruitless and exhausting, and has death as the product?'²¹

When she had said this the Great Being bewildered her by speaking more verses:

6. 'Whoever considers the deed ever unattainable, O Goddess, will not protect his own life; he will know this if he gives up.'

7. Some in this world, Goddess, undertake deeds for the fruit of their intention;
some deeds prosper and some do not.
8. Do you not see, Goddess, the visible fruit of deeds?
for others have sunk; I am crossing and I can see you near me.
9. So I will struggle according to my ability and strength
and go towards the shore of the ocean;
I will do what is to be done by men.'

[37] The goddess heard his brave speech and spoke a verse extolling him:

10. 'You who go on in this measureless sea,
endowed with strength and rightness, and are not worn
down by the task:
go to the place where your heart takes delight.'

When she had said this, she asked, 'Wise man, who has made such a great effort: where can I take you?' He replied, 'To the city of Mithilā'. So she picked him up like a bundle of garlands and, taking him in both arms, got him to lie at her breast and sprang up into the air, carrying him as if he were her dear child. His body inflamed with salt spray, the Bodhisatta slept soundly for seven days, touched by the divine contact. Then she brought him to Mithilā and laid him down on his right side on an auspicious stone²² in a mango grove. There she left him under the protection of the goddesses of the garden and went back to her own home.

Now Polajanaka had not had a son, but he did have just one daughter, a wise and accomplished girl called Princess Sivali. And they had asked him as he lay on his deathbed: 'Great king, when you have gone to the state of being a god, to whom shall we give the throne?' He replied, 'Give it to one who is able to please my daughter, princess Sivali, or who can tell which is the head of the square bed, or who can string the bow that takes the strength of a thousand men or who can bring out the sixteen great treasures.'

They said, 'King: tell us a verse about the treasure.' The king said:

11. 'At the rising of the sun there is treasure and at its setting too.
Inside there is treasure and outside there is treasure;
but there is also a treasure that is neither inside nor outside.
12. [38] Climbing up there is a great treasure
and there is also a treasure in coming down.
At the four sāl trees all around for a yojana there is treasure.
13. At the tips of the teeth there is a great treasure, at the tips of the tail, and in the 'kebuka'.
There is a great treasure at the tips of the trees: sixteen are the great treasures.
There is [that which takes] the strength of a thousand men²³ and a bed for the winning of Sivali.'

He gave an utterance about other treasures as well as these. After the king's death the ministers performed the funeral rites and on the seventh day they met for discussion. 'The king has said that his kingdom should be given to the man able to please his daughter. Now who will be able to please her?' They agreed to summon his favourite, the general of the army. He assented, and in order to gain the kingdom, came to the door of the palace and had his presence announced to the king's daughter. She knew why he had come and thought to herself, 'I wonder if he has the firmness of character to bear the royal parasol?' So in order to test him she had him asked in. He heard her instruction and, anxious to please her, went with great haste up from the foot of the stairs and stood in her presence. In order to test him she said, 'Race quickly up on the flat roof of the palace!' Thinking that he would please the princess, he sprang forward. Then she

said 'Come here!' and he immediately did so. Recognizing his absence of strength she said: 'Massage my feet!' He, in order to please her, sat down and massaged her feet. At this she struck him on the chest with her foot and made him fall over so that he was lying prone on his back. She then gave a sign to her maids, 'Beat this blind and stupid fellow, who is devoid of strength: then grab him by the throat and throw him out.' They then did this. He was asked by the ministers, 'How did it go, general?' He said, 'Just don't talk about it. That woman is not human.'

Then the keeper of the stores came, and she shamed him in the same way. Then too the treasurer, the guardian of the royal parasol and the swordsman: she shamed them all as well. Then the people at large discussed it, 'No one can please the king's daughter; give her to someone who can prepare the bow that needs the strength of a thousand.' But there was no one who could do this. So then they said, 'Give her to the one who knows the head of the square bed'. But no one could determine it. So then they said, 'Give her to the one able to find the sixteen treasures.' But no one could find them. [39] Then they deliberated, 'A kingdom is not protected without a king: what is to be done?'

Then the king's priest said, 'Do not worry: we will send out the wonderful royal carriage.²⁴ A king that is picked up by the royal carriage is able to rule the whole of Jambudipa.' They agreed and had the city decorated, yoked four horses the colour of white lotuses onto the auspicious carriage and spread a coverlet over them. They arranged there the five emblems of royalty²⁵ and surrounded the carriage with a fourfold army.²⁶ Now musical instruments are sounded in front of a chariot with a driver but behind for a chariot without one: so for this case the royal priest said, 'Sound musical instruments behind!' He sprinkled the strap of the chariot and the goad from a golden water jar and said, 'Go where there is someone of sufficient merit to rule the kingdom.'

The chariot encircled the royal palace and then went up the Kettledrum street. The general and all the others thought, 'The

wonderful chariot is coming up to my house!' But it went past all their houses and encircled the city until it left by the eastern gate. It then went on towards the park. When they saw it proceeding so quickly they cried out, 'Stop it!' But the priest said, 'Do not try and stop it; let it go a hundred yojanas if it wants.' The chariot entered the park and circled around the auspicious stone and stopped as though ready for someone to get onto it. The priest saw the Great Being lying there and spoke to his ministers, 'Sirs, someone can be seen lying down on the stone. We do not know if he has the strength of character suitable for the white parasol or not. If he is worthy he will not look at us; but if he is an unlucky person he will get up in fright and look at us, trembling. Quickly: sound all the musical instruments.' So they immediately played all the kinds of musical instruments and the roar was like that of the sea. The Great Being woke up at the noise, uncovered his head and looked out at the mass of people and thought that it must be that they had come for him with the white parasol. So he covered his head again and turned over and lay on his left side. The priest uncovered his feet and inspected the marks that were there.²⁷ 'Let it be him: this man could rule four continents, let alone one.' So he ordered them to sound the musical instruments again.

[40] The Bodhisatta uncovered his face and turned around so that he lay on his right side and looked at the mass of his people. The priest comforted the people and then made an añjali gesture of respect and, kneeling face down, said, 'Rise, sire, the kingdom has come to you.' 'Where has the king gone?' asked the Bodhisatta. 'He is dead.' 'Is there any son or a brother?' 'There is not, sire.' 'Very well, I will take up the kingdom.' Rising up from the stone he sat down cross-legged and was anointed there and then. He was named King Mahājanaka. He then mounted up into the chariot and, having entered the city in royal glory, went to the palace, arranged the general and the others in their positions and then went up to the roof of the palace.

Now, the princess, wishing to test him on first impressions, gave some instructions to one of her attendants: 'Go to the king, approach him and then say that Princess Sīvalī summons him, and that he should come as quickly as possible.' The wise king appeared not to hear her words and commented on the appearance of the palace: 'Ah! Very beautiful.' So the attendant informed the princess that he had been unable to get the king to listen to him. 'Lady, the king heard your message but just praised the palace and did not count your words even as straw.' She thought to herself, 'This must be someone of great character.'²⁸ So she ordered him back a second and a third time. But the king just pleased himself and went up to the palace at his normal pace, stretching like a lion.

Because of the power of his self-confidence the princess could not keep steady as he approached and she gave him her hand to lean on. He took her by the hand and sat down on the royal couch under the raised white parasol. He asked his ministers, 'Sirs, did the king leave any instructions to you when he died?' 'Yes sire,' they said. 'So tell me,' he said. 'He declared that Princess Sīvalī should be given to the person who could please her.' 'Princess Sīvalī gave me her hand to lean on when I came near; that means that I please her. Tell me another of the instructions.' 'Sire, the instructions was to give the kingdom to the one who can determine the head of the square bed.' The king thought to himself, 'This is difficult to work out. But by a trick it should be possible.' So he took a golden hairpin from his head and put it into the princess's hand, saying to her, 'Put this where it belongs.' [41] She took it and placed it at the head of the bed—and just as the proverb says, she gave him the sword.²⁹ For then, through this sign, he knew which was the head. As if he had not heard their discussion about this, he asked what people were saying, and when he had heard, he assured them that it was not wonderful. 'For this is the head of the bed.' He then asked for another

instruction. 'The king ordered that the kingdom should be given to the one who can string a bow needing the strength of a thousand men.' 'Bring it here,' he said. He ordered them to bring the bow and strung it while sitting on the couch, as if it were a woman's bow for carding cotton. 'Tell me another instruction,' he said. 'Sire, the king said the kingdom should be given to the one who can find the sixteen treasures.' 'And what utterances were given about them?'³⁰ he asked. They repeated the verses that have been given earlier, that start with the rising of the sun. When they told him the meaning was as clear as the moon on the surface of the sky. And then he said, 'There is certainly not time today: we'll get the treasure tomorrow.'

The next day he called together the ministers and asked them. 'Did your king feed *paccekabuddhas*?'³¹ They said that he did. He thought to himself, 'The sun that was spoken of is not this sun; *paccekabuddhas* are called rising suns because they are like them. The treasures must be at the place where he met them.' Then the king said, 'When the *paccekabuddhas* came, where did he go to meet them?' They told him that it was at a particular place. So he ordered them to dig at the spot where they ate and brought out the treasure: this they did. He then asked, 'When he followed them and it was time to go where did he stand before he left?' They specified a spot and again he ordered them to dig there and they found some treasure. All the people there sent out a thousand shouts, for at the instruction about the sunrise they had been wandering around digging where the sunrise was; at sunset they had been wandering around where the sun went down. 'But this is the wealth and the wonderful thing is right here.' They gave vent to their joy and happiness. For the 'treasure within' he got them to look at the threshold stone within the main gate of the palace. For the 'treasure outside' he got them to look at the threshold stone outside. And for the treasure 'neither inside nor outside' he got them to look underneath the threshold.

[42] For the 'alighting' he got them to look at the place where they positioned the golden ladder at the time for mounting the state elephant. For 'the dismounting' he had them look at the spot where they dismounted from the elephant's shoulders: 'the four great sāls' were the four great feet, made of sāl wood, at the foot of the platform where they paid homage. He got them to dig treasure pots 'all around for a yojana': now a yojana is the length of a chariot,³² so he had them bring out treasure pots from around the area where they paid respects. 'A great treasure at the tips of the teeth': at the place where the state elephant stood he had them bring out two treasures from the place which faced his two tusks. 'At the ends of the tail': for this he got them to dig up at the place where a state horse stood, at the place facing his tail. 'In the kebuka': this is a name for water, so he had the water of the royal lake drained where a treasure was revealed. For 'the great treasure at the end of the trees' he got them to find treasure pots in the park at the circle where the great sāl tree left a shadow at midday. When he had got them to find sixteen treasures, he asked if there were any other instructions—and they said there were not. The general populace were delighted and the king announced, 'I will throw this wealth into the mouth of generosity!' So in the middle of the city and at the four gates he had five halls for giving built and arranged a great act of giving. And then he called for his mother and the brahmin from the city of Campā and accorded the highest honour to them.

In the youthful days of his reign the son of King Ariṭṭhajanaka, King Mahājanaka, ruled over the entire kingdom of Videha. The whole city was agog to have a look at him and said, 'The king is said to be wise: let's go and see him.' They came from here and there with many presents and arranged a big festival in the city. They covered the palace with elephant rugs and suchlike,³³ arranged perfumes, wreaths and garlands, and soon made a dark

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cloud of cooked grain, flowers, perfumes and incense. They prepared all kinds of food and drink. Then, in order to make offerings to the king, they brought [43] different varieties of foods such as soft and hard foods and drinks and fruits in bowls of silver and gold and stood surrounding him on all sides. The circle of king's ministers sat on one side, the group of brahmins on another, on another such people as wealthy merchants, and on another the most beautiful of the dancing girls. Brahmin chanters of blessings, who sang auspiciously and were skilled in songs for festivals, sang beautiful songs and suchlike and played all kinds of instruments. The king's palace resounded with one roar, like the depths of the Yugandhara ocean, and everywhere one looked the palace trembled. The Great Being sat on the royal throne beneath the white parasol and, regarding the great splendour like the glory of Sakka, remembered his own great struggle in the ocean, and thought, 'Effort is the most suitable thing to be cultivated. If I had not shown such effort in the ocean I would not have acquired this glory.' And joy rose up in him at the recollection of that effort, and with a surge of joy he made this inspired utterance:

14. 'The wise man should take hope and should not become discouraged.
I look at myself; for what I wished for has come to be.
15. The wise man should take hope and should not become discouraged.
I see my own self, who was brought out of the water to dry land.
16. A wise man should work on and not become discouraged.
I look at myself; for what I wished for has come to be.
17. A wise man should work on and not become discouraged.
I look at myself, who was brought out of the water to dry land.

18. The man who possesses wisdom, even though overcome with suffering, should not destroy hope on his way to happiness. There are many kinds of contacts, both beneficial and harmful: those which are not reflected upon lead towards death.³⁴
19. That which was not even thought of has come into being; that which has been thought of will be destroyed. There is no possession consisting of pure thought, for man or woman.'

[44] After that he ruled the kingdom and was unswerving in the ten royal qualities,³⁵ and attended upon the *paccekabuddhas*. After some time Queen Sivalī gave birth to a son endowed with fortunate and auspicious marks, and they gave him the name Prince Dighāvu, or Longlife. When he came of age the king gave him the viceroyalty. Now, one day the gardener brought the king various kinds of fruits and flowers. When he saw them he was delighted, paid the gardener the greatest respects and told him to have the garden decorated and that he would come and see it. The gardener agreed, did as he was asked and had the king notified. The king arrived at the gate of the garden, seated on the shoulders of a fine elephant and surrounded by a large retinue. Now there were two mango trees there, of a lustrous dark colour. One of these did not have any fruit and the other had fruit that was extremely sweet. Because the king had not tasted the mango fruit no one had ventured to pick them. The king, riding by on his fine elephant, picked one fruit from it and ate it, and at the moment it touched the tip of his tongue a taste that seemed divine arose. He thought to himself, 'I'll eat a good amount when I come back.' But when the people realized that the king had eaten the first fruit, from the viceroy right down to the mahouts they picked and ate the fruit, and those who did not get fruit broke the branches with sticks and left the tree plucked bare. So the tree stood, broken and split up, while the other remained with its existing beauty, like a mountain of jewels.

When the king left the garden he saw it and asked his ministers what had happened. 'When everyone saw that the king had eaten the first fruit they plundered it, sire,' came the reply. 'But the other has lost no leaf or colour at all,' he said. 'It did not lose anything because it did not have any fruit,' they replied. At this the king received a sense of urgency. 'This tree stands [45] with its dark lustre because it has no fruit; the other is broken and split because it had fruit. The kingdom is just like a fruitful tree; the life of an ascetic is just like the tree with no fruit. It is the one who has property who has fear, not the one without. I will become like the tree without fruit, not like a fruitful one: so I shall renounce and abandon my worldly success and become a recluse.'³⁶ Making his mind firm he made a resolve and entered the city, stood at the gate of the palace and called for the general of the army. 'Great general, from this day onwards do not let anyone see me except for the servant who brings food and fetches water for my mouth and a toothbrush. Gather my oldest and most eminent ministers and take charge of the kingdom. From now on I am going to live the life of an ascetic on the roof of the palace.' After giving these instructions he duly went up to the roof of the palace and lived an ascetic life alone. As time went by the people met together in the palace courtyard but did not catch sight of the Great Being. 'This is not like our king of old,' they said, and uttered these two verses:

20. 'Alas, our king, the lord of all directions of the earth, is not the one that was of old,
Today he pays no attention to dances nor does his mind turn to songs.
21. He does not even look at the deer in the garden nor the geese,
He remains silent and dumb and does not take charge of anything.'

They asked, it is said, the man who brought food and the attendant whether the king had talked to them or not. They replied that he had not. At this they said, 'The king, through

non-attachment to sense pleasures, with a mind immersed in seclusion, remembers the *paccekabuddhas* associated with his family. He says to himself, "Who will tell me the dwelling place of those beings who possess all excellences such as virtue, and who live possessing nothing?" So he utters these three verses:

22. "Loving happiness, keeping hidden,
ceasing from punishments and imprisonments:
in whose wonderful garden today are they, young and old?
- [46] 23. I pay homage to these wise men.
Firm, and having crossed over the thicket of desire,
they live without longings, in a world that is longing.
24. They have cut through the net of death and the tough
knot of illusion;
They go, with desire cut through: O who will show me
where they have gone?"

After he had been practising the life of an ascetic for four months in his palace he applied his mind intently on going forth. His home seemed like the Niraya hell between the worlds and the three worlds appeared as if on fire.³⁷ With his mind intent upon the prospect of going forth, he embarked upon a eulogy of Mithilā, 'When will the time come for me to be able to leave behind this Mithilā, that is adorned and dressed up like the realm of Sakka, and go into the Himālayas in the dress of an ascetic?

25. O when shall I leave Mithilā, that is so splendid,
spacious and bright on all sides?
When shall I take the going forth, O when is the time
that shall be?³⁸
26. O when shall I leave Mithilā, so splendid and divided
into such even parts?
When shall I take the going forth, O when is the time
that shall be?

27. O when shall I leave Mithilā, so splendid, with its great
ramparts and gateways?
When shall I take the going forth, O when is the time that
shall be?
28. O when shall I leave Mithilā, so splendid, with its strong,
polished storehouse?
When shall I take the going forth, O when is the time that
shall be?
29. O when shall I leave Mithilā, splendid, with its beautiful
divisions and magnificent roads?
When shall I take the going forth, O when is the time that
shall be?
30. O when shall I leave Mithilā, with its well-arranged
bazaars?
When shall I take the going forth, O when is the time that
shall be?
31. When shall I leave Mithilā, splendid with its throngs of horses,
cows and chariots?
When shall I take the going forth, O when is the time that
shall be?
32. When shall I leave Mithilā, splendid with its garlanded
groves and woods?
When shall I take the going forth, O when is the time that
shall be?
33. When shall I leave Mithilā, splendid with its garlanded parks
and forests?
When shall I take the going forth, O when is the time that
shall be?
34. When shall I leave Mithilā, splendid with its garlanded palace
orchards?
When shall I take the going forth, O when is the time that
shall be?
35. When shall I leave Mithilā, splendid with its three turrets,

- filled with kinsmen³⁹ of the king, established in glory by Somanassa the Videhan?
 When shall I take the going forth, O when is the time that shall be?
36. When shall I leave the splendid throngs of the Videhans, the protectors of justice?
 When shall I take the going forth, O when is the time that shall be?
37. When shall I leave the Videhans, splendid, invincible, protectors of justice?
 When shall I take the going forth, O when is the time that shall be?
38. O when shall I leave the harem, so delightful and divided into such even parts?
 When shall I take the going forth, O when is the time that shall be?
39. O when shall I leave the harem, so delightful, with lime-washed clay
 When shall I take the going forth, O when is the time that shall be?
40. O when shall I leave the women's quarters, with its sweet smells that delight the mind?
 When shall I take the going forth, O when is the time that shall be?
41. O when shall I leave the peaked roofs, so splendid and divided into such even parts?
 When shall I take the going forth, O when is the time that shall be?
42. O when shall I leave the peaked roofs, with lime-washed clay?
 When shall I take the going forth, O when is the time that shall be?
43. O when shall I leave the peaked roofs, with their sweet smells that please the mind?

- When shall I take the going forth, O when is the time that shall be?
44. O when shall I leave the peaked roofs, smeared with sprinkled sandalwood?
 When shall I take the going forth, O when is the time that shall be?
45. O when shall I leave the golden couches, covered with brightly coloured woollen rugs?
 When shall I take the going forth, O when is the time that shall be?
46. O when shall I leave the cotton and silk, the fine linen and every kind of cloth?
 When shall I take the going forth, O when is the time that shall be?
47. O when shall I leave the delightful lotus ponds, filled with the sound of ruddy geese,
 and covered with water plants and lotuses of blue, red and white?
 When shall I take the going forth, O when is the time that shall be?
- 48-9. O when shall I leave the troops of elephants, adorned in every way, decked with golden ribbons; the perfumed golden harnesses mounted with village chiefs with kusa grass spears in their hands?
 When shall I take the going forth, O when is the time that shall be?
- 50-1. O when shall I leave the troops of horses, adorned in every way,
 the noble, thoroughbred sindhs with swift chariots, mounted with village chiefs who carry short swords and bows?
 When shall I take the going forth, O when is the time that shall be?

- 52-3 [48]. When shall I leave the military chariots,
 decked, with banners flying, covered in tiger skin
 and adorned in every way,
 mounted with village chiefs clad in armour with
 bows in their hands?
 When shall I take the going forth, O when is the
 time that shall be?
- 54-5. When shall I leave the gilded chariots, decked with
 banners flying,
 and chariots covered with panther and tiger skin,
 adorned in every way, mounted with village chiefs
 clad in armour with bows in their hands?
 When shall I take the going forth, O when is the
 time that shall be?
- 56-69. When shall I leave . . . [same formula for] buffalo-
 led chariots, bull-led chariots, goat-led chariots,
 ram-led chariots and deer-led chariots.
70. O when shall I leave the brave men on elephants,
 adorned in every way,
 clad in black armour, brave with kusa spears in
 their hands?
 When shall I take the going forth, O when is the
 time that shall be?
71. O when shall I leave the brave men on horses,
 adorned in every way, clad in black armour, with
 short swords and bows in their hands?
 When shall I take the going forth, O when is the
 time that shall be?
72. O when shall I leave the brave archers, adorned in
 every way, clad in black armour, carrying quivers
 and with bows in their hands?

- When shall I take the going forth, O when is the
 time that shall be?
73. O when shall I leave the brave royal sons, adorned
 in every way, clad in many-coloured armour,
 wearing golden garlands?
 When shall I take the going forth, O when is the
 time that shall be?
74. O when shall I leave the troop of Ariyans, wrapped
 in cloth, with limbs anointed with yellow
 sandalwood, dressed in fine Benares linen?
 When shall I take the going forth, O when is the
 time that shall be?
75. O when shall I leave the seven hundred wives,
 adorned in every way?
 When shall I take the going forth, O when is the
 time that shall be?
76. O when shall I leave the seven hundred wives with
 beautiful hips and tiny waists?⁴⁰
 When shall I take the going forth, O when is the
 time that shall be?
77. O when shall I leave the seven hundred wives, who
 are loyal and with loving speech?
 When shall I take the going forth, O when is the
 time that shall be?
78. O when shall I leave the fine bronze dish and the
 pure gold plate?
 When shall I take the going forth, O when is the
 time that shall be?
- 79-80.⁴¹ O when will the troops of elephants, adorned in
 every way,
 decked with golden ribbons and the perfumed
 golden harnesses

- mounted with village chiefs with
kusa grass spears in their hands, not follow me as I go?
O when is the time that will be?
- 81-2. O when will the troops of horses, adorned in every way,
the noble, thoroughbred sindhs with swift chariots,
mounted with village chiefs who carry short swords
and bows, not follow me as I go?
O when is the time that will be?
- 83-4. O when will military chariots, decked with banners flying,
covered in tiger skin and adorned in every way,
mounted with village chiefs clad in armour with bows
in their hands,
when will they not follow me as I go?
O when is the time that will be?
- 85-6. O when will the gilded chariots, decked with banners flying,
and chariots covered with panther skin and tiger skin,
adorned in every way, mounted with village
chiefs clad in armour with bows in their hands, not
follow me as I go?
O when is the time that will be?
- 87-100. O when will the . . . [same formula for] buffalo-led
chariots, bull-led chariots, goat-led chariots, ram-led
chariots and deer-led chariots
O when is the time that will be?
101. O when will the brave men on elephants, adorned in
every way, clad in black armour, brave, with kusa spears
in their hands, not follow me as I go?
O when is the time that will be?

102. O when will the brave men on horses, adorned in every way, clad in black armour, with short swords and bows in their hands, not follow me as I go?
O when is the time that will be?
103. O when will the brave archers, adorned in every way, clad in black armour, carrying quivers and with bows in their hands, not follow me as I go?
O when is the time that will be?
104. O when will the brave royal sons, adorned in every way, clad in many-coloured armour, wearing golden garlands, not follow me as I go?
O when is the time that will be?
105. O when will the troop of Ariyans, wrapped in cloth, with limbs anointed with yellow sandalwood, dressed in fine Benares linen, not follow me as I go?
O when is the time that will be?
106. O when will the seven hundred wives, adorned in every way, not follow me as I go? O when is the time that will be?
107. O when will the seven hundred wives, with beautiful hips and tiny waists, not follow me as I go?
O when is the time that will be?
108. O when will the seven hundred wives, who are loyal and with loving speech, not follow me as I go?
O when is the time that will be?
109. O when shall I take the bowl, and with head shaved and dressed in the robe wander in search of alms?
O when is the time that will be?
110. O when shall I wear the robe, made from discarded rags, on the great road?
O when is the time that will be?
111. O when shall I wander, in seven days of storms, rained upon and with robe wet, in search of alms?
O when is the time that will be?

112. O when shall I spend the whole day at a spot at the roots of a tree, in the woody forest, free from longing?
O when is the time that will be?
113. O when shall I live in the mountain heights, with fear and dismay abandoned, without a second person, free from longing?
O when is the time that will be?
114. O when shall I make my mind straight, like a lute player [tuning] his lovely seven-stringed lute?
O when is the time that will be?
115. O when shall I, like a chariot maker⁴² cutting the edges⁴³ for sandals, cut the bonds to the senses, both divine and human?

[52] Now it is said the king was born at a time when the human lifespan was ten thousand years. He spent seven thousand years ruling the kingdom, and became a recluse when he still had three thousand years to live. For four months since the time when he had seen the mango trees at the gate of the park he had lived in his house, thinking, 'It would be better to take the going forth and leave this house.' So he secretly ordered an attendant to go to the market, without anyone else knowing, and bring him back some yellow-brown robes and an earthenware bowl; which he did. The king then ordered his barber to cut his hair and dismissed him. Then he dressed himself with one garment, covered himself with another and wrapped another one over his shoulder. He put the earthenware bowl in a bag and strung that over his shoulder too. Then, taking a walking stick, he walked on the roof of the palace several times backwards and forwards with the carriage of a *paccekabuddha*. That day he remained there, but on the next day at sunrise he began to go down from the palace. Queen Sivali sent for seven hundred of his concubines and said, 'We have not seen the king for a long time—a good four months have passed. But today we will see him, so go and adorn yourselves and, using

your female wiles and most charming behaviour, try hard to entangle him in the knots of passion.' So she went up with them, all dressed up and adorned, determined to see the king. But although she did meet him as he was coming downstairs, she did not recognize him: instead she paid respects and stood to one side as what she thought was a *paccekabuddha*, who had come to give instruction to the king, passed by. And so the king came down from the palace.

When she had ascended to the top floor of the palace she saw the king's hair, the colour of bees, and pieces of his regalia lying by the royal bed: 'That was no *paccekabuddha*! It must have been our dear lord. Come, I'll go and plead with him to come back.' So she came down from the top of the palace and reached the royal courtyard. Then she and the other ladies released their hair so that it tumbled down their backs and beat their chests with their hands. They followed the king, wailing with great emotion, 'O how can you do such a thing, great lord?' The entire city was shaken and they followed the king weeping, 'It is said that our king has gone forth! How will we ever find such a just ruler again?'

Then the Teacher, describing the wailing of the women and how the king left them and went on his way, said:

116. 'Seven hundred wives, adorned in every way, stretched out their arms, crying, "O why are you going to forsake us?"'
117. Seven hundred wives, with beautiful hips and tiny waists, stretched out their arms, crying, "O why are you going to forsake us?"'
118. Seven hundred wives so loyal and with such loving speech, stretched out their arms, crying, "O why are you going to forsake us?"'
119. Seven hundred wives, adorned in every way:
"The honoured king has left us and run away to take the going forth!"

120. Seven hundred wives, with beautiful hips and tiny waists:
"The honoured king has left and run away to take the
going forth!"
121. Seven hundred wives so loyal and with such loving speech:
"The honoured king has left and run away to take the
going forth!"
122. Leaving behind the fine bronze bowl and the pure gold plate,
he has taken up the earthenware bowl, for his second
anointment.'

The weeping Queen Sivali could not prevent the king from going, so she settled on a stratagem, sent for the general of the army and gave him some instructions. 'Sir, start a fire in the old houses and buildings ahead, in the direction in front of the king. Fetch grasses and leaves to that spot and get some smoke going.' He had this done. She then went to the king and, falling at his feet, informed him that Mithilā was burning, and spoke two verses:

123. 'There are terrible pyres, and the stores are burning bit by bit:
silver and gold, and many pearls and gems.
124. Crystals, mother of pearl, cloth, yellow sandal,
antelope skin, ivory goods, copper and much black iron.
Go king and turn back, and do not destroy this wealth of
yours!'

And then the Great Being said, 'Queen, what are you saying? Those who have something can have it burnt. But I have nothing.' In explanation he recited this verse:

125. 'We live happily, those who have nothing.
Mithilā might burn, but nothing has burnt of mine!'

[55] After he had said this the Great Being left by the northern gate and then his wives also left. Then Queen Sivali thought up a trick and gave instructions to them: 'Make it appear as if villages

have been destroyed and that the land is being wasted'. So they explained to the king how, all at the same time, armed men were living by plundering and were running around here and there. Some had sprinkled essence of lac on their bodies and were being laid down on boards, as if wounded, or dead. The people upbraided him with the words, 'Great king, while you are taking care of your affairs they are ransacking the kingdom and killing the people!' And then the queen paid her respects to the king and uttered this verse to persuade him to turn back:

126. 'The wild men have risen up, they are laying waste to the kingdom,
Come, O king, and turn back: do not destroy this kingdom!'

The king thought to himself, 'It just is not true that while I have been taking care of my business thieves have risen up and are devastating the kingdom. This must be Sivali's doing.' And he said this to make the matter clear:

127. 'We live very happily, those who have nothing.
Even though the kingdom is being wasted, nothing is
destroyed for me.
128. We live very happily, those who have nothing;
we exist feeding on joy, like the Gods of Streaming
Radiance!'⁴⁴

Even though he had said this, the crowd still followed the king. So then he thought, 'The crowd do not wish to turn back: I'll have to make them.' When he had gone a length of about two miles⁴⁵ he turned back and, standing on the main road, he questioned his ministers, 'Whose kingdom is this?' They replied, 'Yours, King.' [56] 'Make a royal decree to keep a distance from this line,' he said. So with his ascetic's staff he drew out a line across the road and because of the king's power no one could cross the line he had made. The crowd wailed with a great lament

as they stood under the head of the line. The queen, also unable to cross the line, saw the king going away with his back to her and could not restrain her grief. She beat her breast and then fell prone across the main road and so, by moving forward, went over the line. The crowd said, 'The line has been broken by those that guard it!' and followed where the queen had led. The Great Being went towards the north, to the foothills of the Himālayas. The queen went too, taking with her the army and waggons. The king, still unable to turn back the crowd, went on for sixty yojanas.

Now, at that time there lived an ascetic called Nārada, who lived in the Golden Cave in the Himālayas and practised the five higher knowledges.⁴⁶ After seven days in the happiness of meditation he emerged from it and was exclaiming out loud, 'O, the happiness, the happiness! I wonder if there is anyone in the whole of Jambudīpa searching for this happiness?' With his divine eye he looked around and saw Mahājanaka, and that he was bringing about Buddhahood. 'The king cannot make a great renunciation and turn back the people who are following in Queen Sīvali's wake. They make an obstacle for him, so I'll give him something to say to them that will strengthen his resolve all the more.' By the power of his supernatural abilities he went to the king and appeared before him, standing in the sky, and said this, to produce energy in him:

129. 'What is this great noise, like games in a village?
We ask the ascetic: why is a crowd of people streaming around?'

The king replied,

130. 'The crowd are streaming round as I have left and renounced.
I have gone beyond the boundary, for the attainment of truth;
my departure is mixed with pure delight. Why do you ask,
as you must know this?'

[57] And Nārada said this in order to stir up his strength:

131. 'Do not think you have crossed over while you still carry
a body;
this *kamma* cannot have been crossed over, and there are
still many obstacles ahead.'⁴⁷

Then the Great Being said:

132. 'What danger in this is there for me
as I live in such a way that I do not wish for pleasures in
this world or in the next?'

And Nārada explained the danger by speaking a verse:

133. 'Sleep, laziness, weariness, discontent, drowsiness from food:
for the one living in the bodily frame, there are many dangers.'

[58] Then the Great Being uttered this verse, praising him:

134. 'Certainly the venerable sir, the brahmin, has given lovely
advice.

And so I ask the brahmin: Who are you, sir?'

At this Nārada said:

135. 'Nārada is my name; they knew me as Kassapa.
I have come before you, sir; it is good to meet with noble
men.
136. May you enjoy a completely joyful abiding in this:⁴⁸
and may you supplement anything that is missing with
forbearance and peace!
137. Give up any sense of inferiority and any sense of
haughtiness⁴⁹
and, as you go forth, honour the work to be done, wisdom
and the way that is right.'⁵⁰

In this way he gave advice to the Great Being and returned through the air to his own abode. When he had gone, another ascetic, called Migājina,⁵¹ who had just emerged from meditation,

looking around saw the Great Being and thought he would give him some advice that would turn the great crowd back. He showed himself in the sky above him and said:

- [59] 138. 'You have forsaken, Janaka, the crowds of elephants and horses,
the city dwellers and the countrymen
and, as an ascetic, you have gone for delight in the earthenware bowl.
139. Perhaps countrymen, friends, colleagues or relatives have performed some treachery against you?
Why has it pleased you to do this?'

Then the Great Being said:

140. 'No, Migājina, I have never at any time, in any way,⁵²
overpowered any relative unjustly nor have they overpowered me.'

When he had refuted Migājina's question he spoke revealing his reason for becoming an ascetic:

141. 'When I saw the world turning, being devoured and made muddied
and that ordinary people were harmed and bound here, where they had sunk.
That is when I compared myself to them and became a mendicant, Migājina.'

[60] The ascetic, wishing to hear him expand upon his reason, spoke this verse:

142. 'Who is your lord, your teacher, from whom does this pure statement come?
They say that an ascetic who passes beyond suffering does not reject precepts, or theory, or giving up,
O lord of charioteers.'

And then the Great Being replied:

143. 'No, Migājina, I have never at any time, in any way, honoured an ascetic or brahmin nor approached one for instruction.'⁵³

When he had made this statement, he spoke explaining right from the beginning his reason for going forth:

144. 'As I proceeded, shining in great pomp and majesty, songs were being sung, lovely music was being played. The garden resounded with the play of musical instruments
and was filled with the finest sounds of percussion.
145. I saw, Migājina, a mango tree,
outside the protective wall [of the garden],
destroyed⁵⁴ by people who wanted the fruit.
146. So then I abandoned pomp, Migājina, got down,
and approached the root of the mango tree that was fruitful and the one without fruit.
147. The fruitful mango tree was destroyed and broken,
with stalks removed,
while the other mango tree was shining, with a dark colour and delightful.
- [61] 148. So in this way we kings are beset by many thorns;
our enemies will destroy us just as the fruitful mango tree is harmed.
149. A panther is harmed for its pelt, an elephant for its tusks,
a rich man is harmed for his wealth:
for me, without house or friendship,
the fruitful mango tree and the one without fruit were both teachers.'⁵⁵

When Migājina heard this he exhorted the king to be vigilant and then went back to his own realm. When he had gone Queen Sivali fell at the king's feet and said:

150. 'Elephant drivers, royal guards, charioteers and foot soldiers: the people are all frightened, exclaiming, "the king has gone forth!"
151. When you have set up protection for the people and established your son as king: only when you have come back and done this should you take the going forth.'

Then the Bodhisatta said:

152. 'I have given up countrymen, friends, ministers and relatives.
[62] The Videhans have sons: Longlife is the good luck of the kingdom;
They will look after the kingdom of Mithilā, great queen.'

The queen said: 'Sire, you are becoming an ascetic; what shall I do?' He said, 'I will tell you: do what I say,' and he said this:

153. 'Go, I will teach you a description of what pleases me.
If you take charge of the kingdom,
you will do great evil in body, speech and mind and go to an unfortunate rebirth.⁵⁶
So keep yourself going with almsfood, given by others and prepared by others:
this is the teaching of the strong.'

So the Great Being advised her in this way. And the sun went down as they conversed with one another. Now the queen set up her camp at a suitable spot; the Great Being meanwhile went to the root of a certain tree and stayed there, and on the next day took care of his bodily needs and went on his way. The queen ordered the army to follow behind, and she also went behind him. At the time for going on the alms round they reached a city called Thūṇa. Now at that moment, inside the city, a certain man had bought a large piece of meat from a slaughterhouse and had cooked it on a spit over embers. He then placed it on a board to cool and left it. But while he was occupied with something else

a dog came and ran away with it. When the man realized he followed the dog to outside the southern gate of the city, but became fed up with searching and went back. The king and the queen, separately, were coming up in front of the dog, which dropped the meat in fright and ran off. When the Great Being saw this he thought, 'This dog has dropped the meat and run off without regard, but no other owner can be seen. You could not find such a blameless piece of almsfood.⁵⁷ I'll eat it.' So he took out his earthenware bowl, took the piece of meat, wiped it, put it on the dish, found a pleasant spot where there was water and ate it. The queen saw this and thought, 'If this man were worthy of a kingdom he would not eat such detestable leftovers dropped by a dog. Well, he is not my husband now.' She addressed him, 'Great king, are you eating such disgusting food?' 'Queen, through your blindness you cannot recognize the excellence of this piece of almsfood.' And he contemplated the spot right where it had fallen, ate the food as if it were ambrosia and then rinsed his mouth and washed his hands and feet. At that, the queen addressed him in reproach:

154. 'Whoever does not eat by the time of the fourth occasion for eating
dies from starvation through not eating;
nonetheless a worthy man of good family should not resort to ignoble, dirty almsfood;
this is not good, this is not well done, that you eat the leavings of a dog.'

The Great Being said:

155. 'Sivali, it is not unfitting to eat what has been discarded by a householder or a dog.
Any food that is obtained in accordance with what is right is completely suitable for eating.'

[64] As they debated with each other in this way they reached the gate of the city. There some children were playing and a little girl was pummelling some sand in a little winnowing basket. On one of her wrists there was one bracelet, and on the other two; the two bracelets clinked against each other while the other one made no noise. The king saw the cause of this and said, 'Sīvalī follows behind me; a woman is a stain for a recluse. People will reproach me, regarding me as someone who takes the going forth but cannot leave a woman. If this girl is wise, she will be able to explain a reason for Queen Sīvalī turning back. I'll listen to what she has to say and then send Sīvalī away.' Thinking this he said,

156. 'Little girl, always the darling of your mother, adorned with bracelets,
why does one of your arms make a sound and the other does not?'

The little girl replied,

157. 'Ascetic, on this arm are fastened two bangles.
From their jangling together the sound arises:
this event happens from the second one.
158. Ascetic, on this arm is fastened one bangle.
This, without a second, does not produce a sound.
It remains silent, a sage.⁵⁸
159. The second is a bringer of dispute;⁵⁹
What can a single thing quarrel with?
Solitude brings you happiness in your wish for heaven.'

He heard this statement from the girl and, understanding the cause, explained it to the queen.

160. 'Listen, Sīvalī, to the verses declared by the little girl.
The servant girl reproaches me, for this is what happens
with a second person.

161. This path, good lady, that is walked by travellers, divides in two.
You take one and I'll take another.
Do not call me husband, and do not say "I am your wife" again.'

She listened to his words and, saluting him, said, 'Sire, you take the higher, the right hand path and I'll go on the left'. But after she had gone a little way she could not suppress her grief and went back to the king. And she entered with him into the city.

Explaining the matter the Teacher gave half a verse:

162. 'Conversing in this way they reached the city of Thūṇa.'

[66] After they entered, the Great Being went round for alms and reached the door of an arrow maker. Sīvalī stood to one side. At that time the arrow maker was heating an arrow on a heap of embers, had moistened it with rice water and was making it straight by looking at it with one eye after closing the other. When he saw this the Great Being thought, 'If this is a wise man he'll tell me the reason for this; I'll ask him.' And he approached him.

In explanation the Teacher said,

163. 'When it was time for food at the storehouse of the arrow maker:
there the arrow maker closes one eye and looks sideways with the other.'

And then the Great Being said,

164. 'Listen to me, arrow maker.
It is good that you look in this way,
whereby you look sideways with one eye after closing the other.'

And he, answering him, replied,

165. 'Ascetic, with two eyes, the bow appears as if diffuse.

The arrow maker cannot find the best feature and does not smooth it to straightness.

166. For the person who looks askance with one eye and closes the other,
the arrow acquires the best feature and becomes suited to straightness.
167. The second is the bringer of dispute; what can a single thing quarrel with?
Solitude brings you happiness in the wish for heaven.'

When he had given this advice he was silent. The Great Being went for alms and, having collected some food mixed together, he left the city and sat down in a place which was pleasant and had water. And when he had done everything that he had to do, he put away the bowl in the bag and addressed Sīvalī:

168. 'Listen, Sīvalī, to the verses taught by the arrow maker.
The servant reproached me; this is what happens with a second person.⁶⁰
169. This is a divided path, good lady, for the traveller to follow.
You take one and I'll take another.
Do not you call me husband, and do not say "I am your wife" again.'

They say that although he had asked, 'do not call me husband', she followed the Great Being but could not persuade the king to turn back and the crowd followed her. Not far away there was a forest. The Great Being saw a dark streak of woodland and, wishing to get her to turn back, he broke a reed off from some muñja grass he saw on the roadside. 'Look at this Sīvalī; this cannot be joined together again. So your association with me cannot be joined together again either.' And he said this half verse,

170. 'Live alone, Sīvalī, like a muñja grass reed that has been pulled out.'

She heard this, and cried 'From now on there is no more association with King Mahājanaka for me!' Unable to bear her grief she beat her breast with both hands and fell senseless on to the main road. The Great Being, seeing that she was unconscious, entered into the forest, obliterating his footprints. Ministers came and sprinkled her body with water and massaged her hands and feet to bring her back to consciousness. 'Oh where has the king gone?' she asked. 'Don't you know?' they replied. 'Find him, sirs!' she ordered. But although they ran around here and there they could not see him. She poured forth her grief and had a shrine built at the spots where the king had been, which she honoured with offerings such as flowers and incense, and then turned back. The Great Being entered the Himālaya region and in the course of seven days he cultivated the higher knowledges and the attainments.⁶¹ And he did not go again into the ways of men. The queen had shrines made at all the places he had been: the spot where he had spoken with the arrow maker, the spot where he had spoken with the servant girl, the spot where he had eaten the piece of meat, the spot where he had conversed with Migājina and the one where he had spoken with Nārada. She paid homage to them with incense and flowers and then, surrounded by the army, she went to Mithilā. She had her son anointed in the mango grove and told him to enter into the city surrounded by the army. And then she took the going forth and lived in the grove. She did the preparations for *kaśīṇa* practice and attained the meditation, destined for rebirth in a Brahma realm.⁶²

The Teacher gave this teaching and said, 'Not just now, but in times past the Thus-gone made a great renunciation.' And he made the connections in the births: 'At that time Uppalavaṇṇā was the sea goddess, Sāriputta was Nārada, Moggallāna was Migājina, the nun Khemā was the little girl, Ānanda the fletcher, Rāhula's mother was Sīvalī, Rāhula was prince Dīghāvu,

members of the royal family were the mother and the father and I was Mahājanaka.'

Notes

¹ Someone who has travelled by sea is ranked with arsonists, poisoners and adulterers. See W. Doniger with B.K. Smith, *The Laws of Manu* (Harmondsworth, Middlesex: Penguin, 1991), p. 60 (3.158).

² See H.P. Ray, *The Archaeology of Seafaring in Ancient South Asia* (Cambridge: CUP, 2003), p. 63 and M. Winternitz, *History of Indian Literature* (Srinivasa Sarma revised), 2 vols. (Delhi: Motilal, 1983), II, p. 127, n. 2. Seafaring Jātakas include 196, 360 and the Suppāraka Jātaka (463), a famous tale where the Bodhisatta is a skilled mariner.

³ J I 60.

⁴ At the shrine hall at Wat Yai Intharum, Chonburi. See S. Leksukhum, with photos by G. Mermet, 'The Ten Great Jātakas', *Temples of Gold: Seven Centuries of Thai Buddhist Paintings* (London: Thames and Hudson, 2001), p. 140. Also at Wat No, Suphanburi, Thailand. See E. Wray, C. Rosenfield, D. Bailey, with photographs by J.D. Wray, *Ten Lives of the Buddha: Siamese Temple Paintings and Jātaka Tales* (New York: Weatherhill, 1996, rev. edn), p. 35.

⁵ *History of Indian Literature*, p. 142.

⁶ See Thompson, *Motif Index*, 'suitor tests/quest', H336 and H1200–H1399. See also S. Thompson and J. Balys, *The Oral Tales of India* (Bloomington, Indiana: IUP, 1958), motif index nos H 305–88.

⁷ The Ummagga Jātaka (546) is particularly popular in Sri Lanka. For the use of riddles there, see Nandasena Ratnagalle, *Folklore of Sri Lanka* (Colombo: State Printing Corporation, 1991), pp. 125–33.

⁸ It should be noted that the verses do not mention the *paccekabuddha* by name. At the time of the first composition of Jātakas it seems that the term had not been developed fully. On *paccekabuddhas* in the canon, see DPPN II 94–6, Winternitz, *History of Indian Literature*, p. 141, n. 3, and J. Garrett Jones, *Tales and Teachings of the Buddha: The Jātaka Stories in Relation to the Pāli Canon* (London: Allen and Unwin, 1979), pp. 166–70. The Pāli *suttas* place less emphasis on these figures than

the later tradition. They do not feature in any Jātaka verses. For fuller studies of the subject, see K.R. Norman, 'The Pratyeka-Buddha in Buddhism and Jainism', *Selected Papers*, Vol. II (Oxford: PTS, 1991), pp. 233–49, and R. Kloppenborg, *The Paccekabuddha: a Buddhist ascetic. A study of the concept of paccekabuddhas in Pāli canonical and commentarial literature* (Lieden: Brill, 1974).

⁹ Other Jātakas where they appear include 408, 420, 421, 424, 442, 459 and 529.

¹⁰ See Kumbhakāra Jātaka (408). These two incidents feature in Jain and Buddhist texts, suggesting an earlier strain of spiritual practice absorbed by both traditions. See K.R. Norman, 'The Pratyeka-Buddha'.

¹¹ See Cone and Gombrich, *Perfect Generosity*, p. 73 (J VI 565–6).

¹² See 'The Bodhisatta Vow: the far past'.

¹³ A famous poem, 'The Rhinoceros Horn', also eulogizes a solitary spiritual existence (Sn 35–75).

¹⁴ Mithilā, the capital of the Videhan country, is mentioned in 22 Jātakas (see, in this volume, 'The Story of Makhādeva', 9). Mahājanaka's eulogy to the city provides us with its fullest description. It is said to be seven yojanas long and was visited by the Buddha. It is usually identified with Janakapura, a small town within the Nepal border region (DPPN II 635).

¹⁵ A *saccakiriya*, a statement of truth with magical efficacy, features in Jātakas 20 and 75.

¹⁶ An example of the Bodhisatta's less than exemplary behaviour when the occasion demands!

¹⁷ Reading *rajjaggahaṇappamāṇo* with a Burmese manuscript (Bd) so that 'for taking the kingdom' is in the nominative.

¹⁸ That is, 350 people.

¹⁹ Amending to *loṇodakena*, 'with salt water'.

²⁰ The Four Great Kings are the protective deities of the Buddhist tradition. They rule the heaven realm above the humans, though take their place also as inhabitants in the realm above that, the heaven of the Thirty-Three Gods (*Tāvātimsa*). As guardians of each cardinal direction they are thought to protect anyone who keeps the *uposatha* day. The intervention of the goddess is a kind of overdetermination that

vindicates the power of the *uposatha*: for the seven days before she does not notice the Bodhisatta, but decides to look after he has kept it. Maṇimekalai is the heroine of a Tamil folk epic, written by Sattanar in the fifth to the sixth century CE. Buddhism flourished in Tamil Nadu and it seems she was adopted as a protective goddess of the sea. See H. P. Ray, *The Archaeology of Seafaring*, pp. 270–1.

²¹ Reading *abhinippaṇṇam*, 'produced', 'accomplished' with Bd, as suggested by PED 65, to give 'product'.

²² I have been unable to find any account of these auspicious slabs, though they feature elsewhere in the Jātakas (J I 59).

²³ We see a few lines later that this is a bow.

²⁴ The word *phussa* means speckled, then brightly coloured and festive (PED 480). This wonderful state carriage is also described in J II 39 and J III 238.

²⁵ These are a sword, the white parasol, the turban, slippers and a yak's tail fan, mentioned in Jātaka 538.

²⁶ An army that extends on four sides, a traditional term, here perhaps meaning that the army has flanks in front of, behind, and on both sides of the carriage.

²⁷ In his last birth thirty-two auspicious marks were discerned on his body which meant that he would be either a wheel-turning monarch or a Buddha. (See *Lakkhaṇa Sutta*, D III 142–79.) Although this is not his last birth, as a royal human in this birth he probably displays some. The marks pertaining to the feet are that his feet are well planted, so that he walks evenly and with level tread, that the mark of a wheel appears on the feet (and palms of his hands) and that he has extended heels. He has long fingers and toes that are like a net, and his hands and feet are soft and tender.

²⁸ *Mahājjhāsāyo*: motivation, disposition.

²⁹ The Jātaka trans. (PTS), VI, p. 26, n. 1 refers the reader to the *Kathāsaritasāgara*, *The Ocean of Story*, sections 72, 47 and 54, where the snake maiden gives the hero a sword and horse. See Thompson, 'Bride helps suitor perform his tasks', *Motif Index*, H 335.01 for counterparts in Irish, Icelandic, German, Italian and Japanese folk tale.

³⁰ *Udāna*: literally an inspired or joyful utterance (PED 134 and DP 421–2).

³¹ *Pacceka*buddhas are fully self-enlightened (*sāmaṇi*), but do not teach the full path to awakening.

³² A *yojana* has two meanings: the yoke of a carriage, used as the length meant here, and a measure of a distance of about seven miles, used earlier in the story from the past.

³³ See DP I 77.

³⁴ According to the *Abhidhamma* system, contact (*phassa*) is the first universal mental factor (*cetasika*) common to all mental states and sensory experience. We are experiencing such contacts all the time. According to the same system, *vitakka*, initial thought or the bringing of the mind to an object, is the first factor involved in the attainment of the first *jhāna*, the first meditation. Where *vitakka* occurs in such a state and indeed in any good, skilful state of mind, it is associated with the second factor of the eightfold path, right intention. Contacts 'which are not reflected upon' (*avitaṅkita*) are therefore those which have not been investigated with mindfulness and skilful attention. The word *vitakka* does sometimes have a negative connotation in the *suttas* (M I 211–14) and indeed in the *Abhidhamma*, in consciousness where attention is wrongly placed. Here, however, *vitakka* is clearly meant to have a positive association as the correct application of the mind in response to any contacts that arise (See DhS 1, 2, 7 and 21).

³⁵ These are given in Jātaka III 274 as generosity (*dāna*), virtue (*sīla*), letting go (*pariccāga*), straightness, gentleness, asceticism, lack of anger, non-harm, forbearance (*khanti*), and non-opposition. Three of these, generosity, virtue and forbearance, are the same words used for three of the perfections to be developed by the Bodhisatta. Lack of anger is considered to be the same as a fourth, loving kindness.

³⁶ The same story is given about a king in Jātaka 408: the king becomes a *pacceka*buddha, an option not chosen by the Bodhisatta given his vow to attain Buddhahood. The similarity, however, reinforces the constant evocation of the *pacceka* path suggested in this story.

³⁷ The three worlds refer to the sense sphere, the heavens above that (*brahmaloka*) and the formless (*arūpa*) realms.

³⁸ These verses are very repetitive: like all bardic and oral literature they depend heavily on repetition and stock formulae. A particular force would accompany the chanting of this section by, as would be usual, a

group of monks who have all themselves chosen to renounce the worldly life. The lay life is described here in what would be perceived as its most glorious form: the wording of the eulogy of the city of Mithilā is very like that used to describe the palace and city of the universal monarch in the *Mahāsudassana Sutta* (D II 190–2). As with many verses of this type the repetitions are not rigidly mechanical: a group of chanters would need to be alert to catch the variations. The second line is the same for each verse from verse 25 to verse 47.

³⁹ For *bandhunī*, 'kinsmen', used here, see commentary and entry for *bandhunī* in PED 482.

⁴⁰ See PED 715 for 'hips', here *susoññā* rather than 'of good understanding' (*susaññā*): as this feature is linked with small waists, this translation seems more likely!

⁴¹ Verses 79–108 follow the same pattern as for verses 48–77, with the people and animals being left in Mithilā becoming active in the questions as the ones who will no longer follow his movements. The break between the two sections is marked, crucially, in the impersonal objects left behind in verse 78, 'the fine bronze dish and the pure gold plate'. They of course cannot follow the king and, in verse 109, the third section of this extended lyrical outburst moves to the contrasting eating accoutrement associated with the going forth: the earthenware bowl of the mendicant. The 'fine bronze bowl and golden plate' are not forgotten: they recur in verse 122, uttered by the Buddha, as signs of the royal, lay life, this time directly contrasted with the earthenware bowl, the emblem of the monastic.

⁴² The text has a chariot maker (*rathakāro*), an odd choice of profession. Skills tend to be transferable amongst Indian craftsman so perhaps the man who carved the wood for a chariot was also called upon to make the templates for sandals?

⁴³ On the suggestion of the Sri Lankan manuscript (Cs) and PED 421 (under *parikanta*) I have read *pariyantaṃ*, ('limit', 'border') here to give 'edges'.

⁴⁴ A Brahma heaven realm where those are born who have attained the second meditation, characterized by joy, happiness and one-pointedness. See Jātaka 99.

⁴⁵ It says a *gāvuta*, which was about two miles (PED 250).

⁴⁶ This Nārada features in *Sudhābhojana Jātaka* (Jātaka 535), where he is also said to be Sāriputta in an earlier birth as is the case in this tale. The higher knowledges are the psychic powers (*iddhis*), said to become available to the practitioner after he has attained the fourth meditation (*jhāna*). Sometimes the list appears with a sixth (D III 281), the destruction of the corruptions (*āsavas*), associated with the attainment of enlightenment. As Nārada has himself made a vow to become the chief disciple of the Buddha, he would not have taken this option.

⁴⁷ This passage poses a number of linguistic difficulties; it appears to rest both upon an inference that the Bodhisatta is claiming to be enlightened and Nārada's almost brahminical interpretation that while there is still a body there can be no freedom from defilements. In Buddhist terminology the one who has 'crossed over' (*tiṇṇo*) is enlightened and has left behind defilements, though here this would be an inappropriate term as the Bodhisatta has postponed his enlightenment until his final lifetime. While the Bodhisatta claims in verse 130 only to have stepped over the town boundary, he clearly regards this as a step symbolic of the freedom of the ascetic life and perhaps Nārada felt he was underestimating the inner dangers ahead. At any rate Nārada's use of the word seems to be a satiric play incorporating some or all of these levels of meaning. He is saying that the Bodhisatta might have crossed over the town boundary, that symbolizes his movement to the ascetic life, but he still needs to be vigilant. The Bodhisatta accepts the admonishment with good grace (verse 134).

⁴⁸ Lit. 'may a completely joyful abiding come to pass for you'. The commentary says that he refers to the four divine abidings (*brahmavihāras*) of loving kindness, compassion, sympathetic joy and equanimity. This verse is a free translation of lines which would be stilted if translated literally.

⁴⁹ For the translation 'haughtiness', see *unnatañ* (DP I 434–5).

⁵⁰ *Kammaṃ vijjā ca dhammaṃ*. The commentary, in perhaps a rather cumbersome manner, relates the first to the ten skilful kinds of action, the second to the five higher knowledges and the meditative attainments and the third to the preparatory work for the *kaṣiṇa* practice.

⁵¹ Migājina is identified at the end with the arahat Moggallāna, the other chief disciple of the Buddha in his last life.

⁵² PED 282 suggests that *na jātucca* in the text should be *na jātu ca*, 'not at all', 'never'.

⁵³ This verse follows almost exactly the same grammatical pattern as verse 140.

⁵⁴ Reading *hatamānaṃ*, 'damaged', 'harmed', with a Burmese manuscript (Bd).

⁵⁵ These verses pose difficulties, but I have by and large followed the commentary's suggestions.

⁵⁶ *Rajjaṃ tuvaṃ kārayantī* (*kāreti*, DP I 652). It is not clear whether the king is advising his queen not to administer the kingdom or discouraging her from installing their son. I have taken it as advice for the queen herself, given perhaps because she is a woman, or because she personally will generate unfortunate *kamma* by being a monarch. The commentary takes it to mean that there will be an unfortunate outcome from installing their son as king and taking charge herself too. It is unlikely to be a warning against her installing the son. The conclusion of the story does not suggest that the son's assumption of the throne is anything other than desirable. Given her attitude towards the king at the end of the story it is improbable that Sivalī would encourage her son to be king if her husband had disapproved of it (for *kārayantī* see DP I 652).

⁵⁷ Literally 'such a blameless piece of alms food does not exist'.

⁵⁸ *Munibhūto*. A *muni* meant originally a teacher who has taken a vow of silence.

⁵⁹ Here, as in verse 167, I have followed a Burmese manuscript (Bd) to read *vivādappatto*, 'full of' or 'with' dispute.

⁶⁰ The Pāli is very unclear here and gives 'servant' in the feminine, as in the comparable verse after the little girl has spoken (v. 160). As the arrow maker is mentioned, however, I have taken him as the servant (taking *peṣṣiyo* with a Sri Lankan manuscript, Cks) and adjusted the text to the masculine, to create what seems to be an intended parallel between this and verse 160. The verse seems to be corrupt, however, and it may be that the 'servant' once referred to the girl with the bangle (for an emendation based on this supposition, see VRI).

⁶¹ The attainment (*samāpatti*) are the eight meditations (*jhāna*) with, sometimes a ninth—the attainment of cessation (*nirodha samāpatti*), only obtainable by stream enterers. This should not be accessible to a Bodhisatta, who postpones his enlightenment though, as the next story (540) demonstrates, he does appear to attain such a state even when not a stream enterer.

⁶² *Jhānaṃ*. It does not say which meditative state. The *kasiṇa* practices are meditations on one of the elements, or a colour, for which a device is constructed.